

Closed – Class System in English Grammar: Auxiliaries and Pronouns

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Abstract

The word class system in the English Language is broadly categorized into two: open class system and closed-class system. The former is characterized by limitless membership, intra and inter-class mobility, transparency and accommodativeness as against the restricted membership, rigidity and limited membership of the closed-system. The members of the open class system are nouns, main verbs, adjectives and adverbs while the closed-system include: pronouns, auxiliary or operator verbs, prepositions, interjections, determiners/articles, quantifiers and enumerators. While traditional grammar (TG) used criteria of form and meaning in classifying and defining “parts of speech” in English, modern grammar (MG) adopted a tripartite criteria of form (morphology), meaning (semantics) and lastly, function (syntax). Of all the three criteria, function has proven to be the most valid, efficient and reliable parameter for word class analysis. In this stead, this paper would evaluate the membership of the closed-class system and their roles in larger syntactic or grammatical structures such as phrases, clauses and sentences in the English language.

Keywords: Word class, Closed-class system, Traditional grammar, Modern grammar, Descriptive linguistics

INTRODUCTION AND THEORETICAL BACKGROUND

The study of grammar could be periodised into two: traditional grammar (prescriptive in nature) and modern grammar (descriptive in nature). In traditional grammar, rigid rules were made on what constituted 'right or wrong' grammar, 'correct or incorrect' grammar, 'good or bad' grammar, 'grammaticality or ungrammaticality' and many more. Scholars of this period (Butter 33, Lowth 21, Cobbett 21), (qtd in S.H Olu Tomori 1-8) churned out some rigid rules in consonance with classical languages (Greek and Latin) and used

them as sole yardsticks to determine what constituted right or wrong grammars. It was at this backdrop, that Dionysus Thrax, a 5th century Greek Philosopher proposed the “eight parts of speech” schema used in considering word classes before the modern era. The “Thraxian” classification was hinged on the use of two parameters – form (morphology) and meaning (semantics) as basis for the “parts of speech”. (Ndimele 32) The eight parts of speech are:

1. Noun: A name of a person, animal, place or things
2. Pronoun: A word which substitutes a noun or used instead of a noun
3. Verb: A word which expresses an action or command
4. Adjective: Any word which modifies or specifies the reference of a noun or pronoun
5. Adverb: Any word which modifies a verb, and adjective and even another adverb
6. Conjunction: Any word which is used to join two or more constructions
7. Preposition: A word which shows the relationship between it and the noun or pronoun that is governed by the preposition
8. Interjection: A word used to express an emotion such as pain, anger, surprise, happiness, anxiety among others (Ndimele 32)

In the light of the above, Daniel Eluke posits that: “it is clearer that the proponents of “parts of speech” hinged their definitions on using the parameters of form and meaning in determining word class system of the English language...” (393). The two parameters – form and meaning are inefficient, insufficient, unreliable in determining the actual classes which words belong in English. This, however, explains the flaws in the definitions in the foregoing.

Secondly, another model of grammar evolved, which is modern grammar (descriptive grammar), wherein, scientific or descriptive methods are deployed in describing languages. In this stance, rules were supplanted by scientific methods adopted in the study or analysis of language including the English language. While the old order used secondary parameters in their classification, the new order (modern grammar) prioritised the primary criterion. Again, modern grammar gives preeminence to the oral medium over the written medium. The principle of the primacy of the oral medium became dominant, in this era, because every normal child learns to speak (oral) before such a child could acquire a writing skill in the said language. To buttress our point on the criteria for word class analysis, Ozo-mekuri Ndimele admits:

In defining word classes, three major criteria are taken into account. They are the form of the word, the meaning of the word and most importantly, the function the word performs in the larger construction in which it occurs. Form and meaning are secondary criteria for determining word classes and therefore do not provide criteria for determining word classes and therefore do not provide enough guide to enable one assign words to their 'correct classes' (32)

From the informed stance of Ndimele, the traditional grammarians considered the secondary elements before the primary element. In his opinion, Eluke points out that this is a case of placing a cart before a horse. It should have been the other way round (394)

In another development, Nkem Okoh informs that:

... Having, in all, been confronted by the limitations of form and meaning, in other words, employing semantic and structural parameters to determine the classes of words, it becomes logical to emphasize the criterion of function. This simply means that we can “define” any word better by considering how it functions in a context. Thus, while the previous criteria (meaning and form) can deceive us in an attempt to “define” that is, classify words, that of function is constant and will not fail (40)

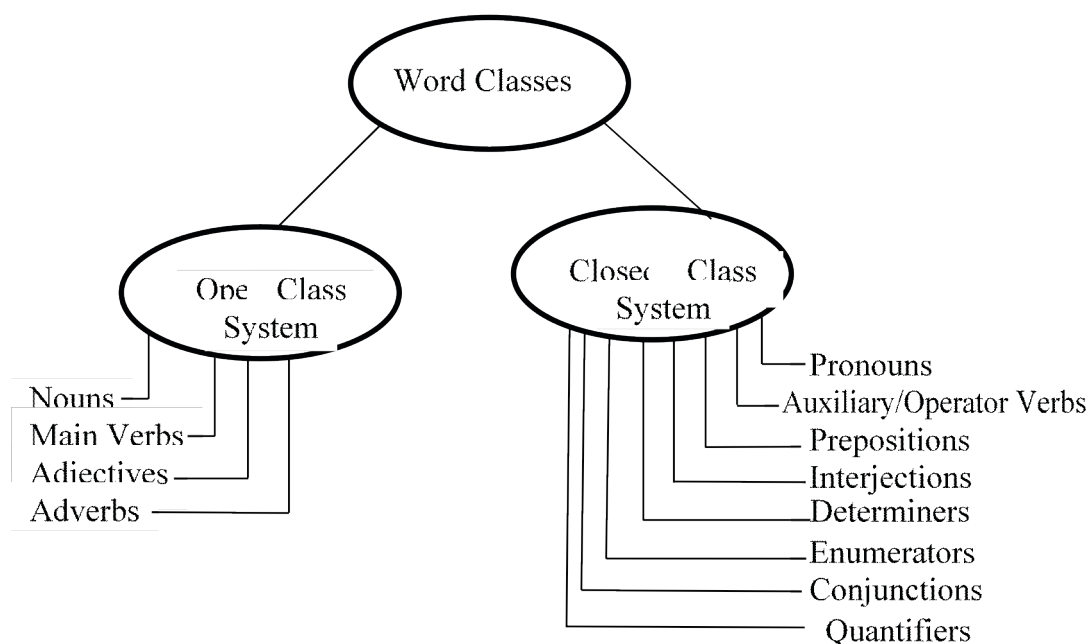
There are plethora of words in English which share same morphological features (form) and semantic relationships (meaning) but perform different roles in larger constructions and at same or different contexts. Besides, Okoh considers this:

... while amusing clearly demonstrates an -ing suffix, it is clear that depending on its context, it can be classified either as an adjective, a verb or even a noun. Similarly, dancing for example, with its clear-ing ending can function either as a noun, an adjective or a verb in the following: The ladies are *dancing*. They are really into the art of *dancing*, you can call them *dancing* ladies (37-38)

It is evident that form and meaning are not sufficient grounds to determine word classes in English as traditional grammar had attempted to push for.

However, a more reliable approach or route is that of function which is more scientific, sufficient, efficient and most reliable. This is the model of modern grammar that this work would adopt in dissecting the different word classes, especially, the closed-class system in English. However, it is not a decoy to disparage the foundation of traditional grammar, in this regard, but an improvement on what it had started.

WORD CLASS SYSTEMS: OPEN VERSUS CLOSED CLASS



The word classes which belong, here, are nouns, main verbs, adjectives and adverbs. They are limitless in number. In other words, the members of this class are accommodating. Coinages and neologisms into the language are accommodated within this system. According to Nkem Okoh: ... “they are referred to as open because we can easily invent or introduce new words (whether real or nonsense, e.g. slithy/toves) into such classes (42). Again, there is intra-class and inter-class mobility within this fold. Members of this system are dynamic and not static or restrictive as what is obtainable in the closed-class system (Eluke 396)

Closed – Class System

The examples of words in this category include: Pronouns, auxiliary/operator

verbs, prepositions, conjunctions, interjections, determiners/articles, quantifiers and enumerators. They are very few in number but are, also far less fluid (Okoh 43). Members are fairly fixed. These words are limited in number and rigid to the extent that they do not accept or admit new members into their folds. There is a restriction in the membership drive of this group.

CRITERIA FOR WORD CLASS IDENTIFICATION

While traditional grammar used criteria of form and meaning in classifying and defining “parts of speech” in English, modern grammar adopted a tripartite criteria of form (morphology), meaning (semantics) and function (syntax). Of all the three, function proves to be more dependable, reliable and efficient in determining the class of words in English. Where form and meaning fail, function flourishes. There are cases where words with same morphological shapes and semantic relations are used in larger structures and they function differently. Some examples suffice here: (v-ed forms: played, danced, walked) – verbs and some adjectives (flabbergasted, magnified, instigated, unwanted, unsigned, conceited, educated and embattled etc.) (Okoh 38)

There are other examples as in:

- 1) The player has to position the ball correctly if not, the referee will sanction him.
- 2) I hope the referee does not caution the midfielder
- 3) Please mention this to the lecturer in charge first
- 4) The commissioner of police has already been petitioned

However, the following words: 'position', 'sanction', 'caution', 'mention', 'petitioned', seem to be in a form of nouns, they perform the roles of verbs in the different contexts in the foregoing sentences. The examples corroborate the stance that, form, as a criterion for word class analysis, is flawed, defiant and insufficient.

The same defects occur in the use of meaning as another yardstick. To use meaning, as a criterion, is deceitful and treacherous. According to Okoh; “... but this ranks as a grossly wrong assumption, especially, as we have already underlined that words constantly dress themselves in extremely slippery, even treacherous robes (33-34)

Again, there are some examples below:

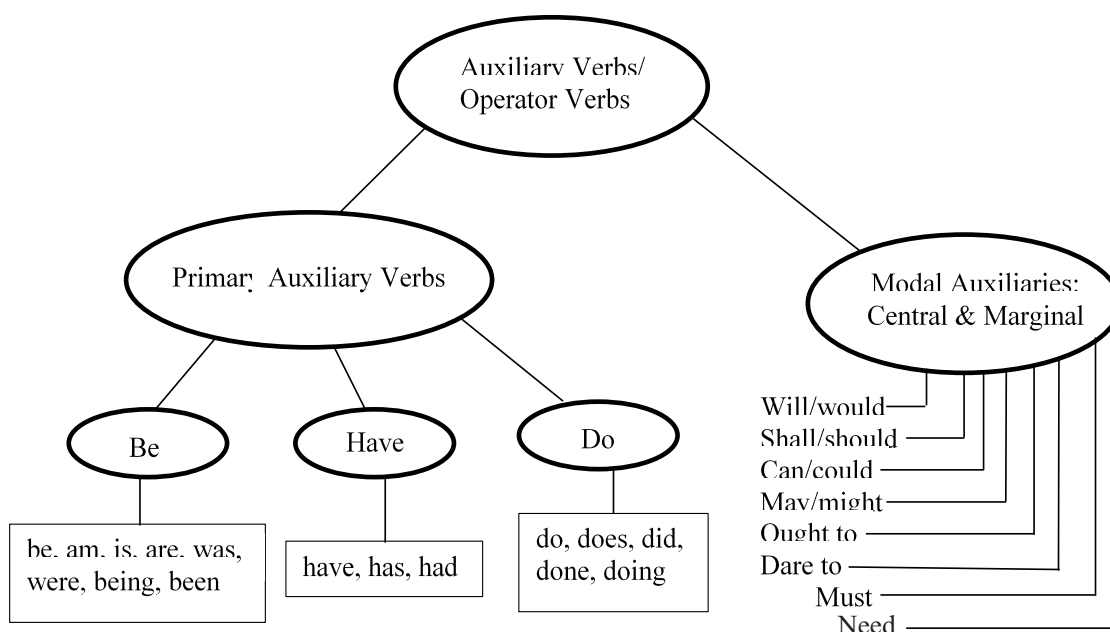
- (1) Please sir, can we have some water to water the plants in the garden?

1 2

- From the examples above, the underlined words have same form and meaning but function differently as used in their respective sentences. While 'some water' (noun) 'to water' (verb), love (1) (verb), love (2) (noun), think (1) (verb), think (2) (adjective), thinking (3) (noun). The same apply to feel (1) as a verb, and the second as an adjective.

DETAILED ANALYSIS OF CLOSED-CLASS SYSTEMS: AUXILIARIES AND PRONOUNS

Based on the syntactic criterion, English verbs are classified, into Primary Auxiliary Verbs and Modal Auxiliaries. They belong to the closed-class system and are diagrammatically presented below:



(Source: Daniel Eluke 396)

There are some features or characteristics of auxiliary verbs in English as the following:

- (a) Auxiliary verbs permit contracted negative (n't) while the lexical or main verbs do not permit this.
- (b) In Yes – No questions or Wh – questions, where a word or phrase from the object position is queried, the auxiliary verb rather than the lexical verb moves to a position immediately before the original subject at the sentence.
- (c) Auxiliary verbs help in reducing monotony since they can enable the speaker to avoid repeating main verbs.
- (d) Auxiliary verbs especially (do) can be used for insistence in certain situations while the lexical do not have such capacity (culled from Ndimele 91 – 92).
- (e) An auxiliary verb can occur without a lexical verb but only where the latter is omitted because it is supplied by a previous context.
- (f) Some auxiliary verbs have contracted positive forms which can be used after a pronoun. E.g. He's going. He is going.
- (g) Quantifiers such as all, both, each, which, modify their subject and the

clause may occur after the first auxiliary:

All the boys will be there

Both my parents are working

However, it is instructive to note that the aforementioned features apply to both primary auxiliary verbs and modal auxiliaries or modals.

Modal Auxiliary Verbs (Central and Marginal Modals)

Non Negative	Uncontracted Negative	Contracted Negative
Can	Cannot, cannot	Can't
Could	Could not	Couldn't
May	May not	Mayn't
Might	Might not	Mightn't
Shall	Shall not	Shan't
Should	Should not	Shouldn't
Will, 'll	Will not, 'll not	Will't
Would 'd	Would not	Won't
Must	Must not	Mustn't

Marginal Modals

Dare	Dare not	Daren't
Need	Could not	Needn't
Ought to	Ought not to	Oughtn't to
Used to	Used not to	Didn't use to

The modals (marginal) construction is mainly restricted to negative and interrogative sentences whereas the main verb constructions can always be used and more common. However, 'dare', and 'need' as modals are rarer in American English than in British English.

Modality of Modals or Modal Auxiliaries

The semantic behaviour of modals is associated with what have been termed as modality in English. Modality may be defined as the manner in which meaning of the clause is qualified so as to reflect the speakers judgment of the likelihood of the propositions it expresses as being true. In the modals, the constraining factors of meaning mentioned above may be divided into two types:

- (i) Permission, obligation and volition which some kind of intrinsic human control over events.
- (ii) Possibility, necessity and prediction which do not necessarily involve human control of events but do, typically, involve human judgment of what is or not likely to happen. Consequently, these two kinds of modality may be termed intrinsic and extrinsic modalities respectively. We can deduce two points about the modals:
 - (i) Each of them has both intrinsic and extrinsic uses. For instance, 'may' has the meaning of permission or intrinsic meaning of possibility which belongs to the extrinsic modality.
 - (ii) The modals themselves tend to have overlapping meanings such that, in some context, they can be more or less interchangeable. Another visible manifestation of this is in the use of 'should' and 'ought to' which one or less interchangeable with the meaning of obligation and tentative inferences. These two points explain why the use of the modals is one problematic areas where many studies have been done.

Can/Could

There are three major meanings of these central modals as in the following:

- (i) There is a meaning of 'possibility' as reinforced in the following sentences:
 - (a) Even expert pilots can make mistakes
 - (b) His performance was the best that could be hoped for
 - (c) If it rains by the day, the sports can take place indoors.
- (ii) There is another meaning of 'ability'. Here, instances abound such as:

- (a) Can you remember where she lives?
- (b) Chituga could speak three languages by the age
- (c) They claim Tony can cook better than his wife
- (iii) There is a meaning of 'permission'. There are some examples:
 - (a) Can we borrow these books from the library?
 - (b) In these days, only men could vote in elections.

May/Might

These modals have two meanings: 'possibility' and 'permission'. In such circumstances of the former, the following examples suffice:

- (a) They may never succeed
- (b) You might be right
- (c) There might be some complaints

However, these examples suggest the most common meaning of /may/ is that of possibility but not in the sense as the possibility of 'can'. As regards to sense of permission, the instances are:

- (a) You may borrow my pen if you wish
- (b) Students may reclaim travel expenses up to a limit of five thousand naira
- (c) Might I ask whether you are using the computer?

As a permission, the auxiliary, 'may' is more formal and less common than 'can' which can be substituted for it. 'May' is particularly associated with 'permission' given by the speaker, that is, the difference is sometimes felt between the preposition 'or' in British English. 'Might' is used as a more tentative and therefore, a polite variant of 'May'.

Will/Would

They have two semantic implications: 'Prediction' and 'Volition'. With respect to the former, three related uses of will/ would are to be distinguished:

- (i) These modals have a future predictive sense:
 - (a) You will feel better after this medicine.
- (ii) There is present predictive of 'will' which is comparative:
 - (a) She will have had her dinner by now.
- (iii) The habitual prediction or description of personal habits:
 - (a) If litmus paper is dipped in acid, it would turn red.
 - (b) Oil will float in water.
 - (c) He would talk for hours, if you let him.

However, the volitional use of insistence is rare and it implies willfulness on the

part of the subject reference. In this case, the auxiliary cannot be contracted to "ll":

- (a) If you will go out without your rain coat, what can you expect?
- (b) She would keep interrupting me.

Shall

This, in present-day English, especially in American English, is rather rare auxiliary and has only two uses both with first person subject. The first modality relates to prediction, especially, with first person subject:

- (a) According to opinion polls, I shall win quite easily
- (b) When shall we know the result of the election?

In contrast, in British English, the prescriptive tradition of grammar forbids 'will' as a future auxiliary with 'I' and 'We'. This prescription is old fashioned and therefore, ignored nowadays. The second use of 'shall' has to do with the sense of volition with first person subject. In the intentional sense of volition, 'shall' is a formal use and traditionally, denotes compulsion.

Ought to/Should

Like 'must' and 'have got to', 'ought to/should' express the senses of necessity and obligation. However, according to Quirik et al. in *A Comprehensive Grammar of English*, the term which best describes 'ought to'/'should', is tentative inferences, that is, the speaker does not know if his/her statement is true but tentatively, concludes that it is true on the basis of what he/she knows:

- (a) The mountains should be visible from here
 - (b) The plant ought to/should reach maturity after five years.
- Ought to/should differ from 'must' in that they frequently refer to the future.

- (a) The job should be finished by next Monday
- Like 'must', 'ought to'/'should' also express the meaning of obligation:
You should do as he says

From the examples, we can deduce that like 'must', 'ought to'/'should' imply the speaker's authority. They do not imply that the speaker has confidence that the recommendation would be carried out, 'ought to' / should has a weaker modality.

Must

'Must' has two modal meanings: 'logical necessity' and 'obligation or

compulsion'. With the former, we have the following examples:

- (a) There must be mistakes
- (b) You must be feeling tired
- (c) The Odilis must have a lot of money

The logical necessity meaning of 'must' implies that the speaker judges the proposition expressed by the sentence to be necessity true or at least, to have a high likelihood of been true. 'Must', in these sense, means that the speaker has drawn a conclusion from things already known or observed. It is imperative to note that 'must' as a logical necessity cannot normally, be used in interrogative or negative sentences. In this case, the negative form of 'can' fills the gap so that "you must be joking" means the same thing as "you can't be serious". However, 'must' relates to obligation or compulsion in the following:

- (a) You must be back at 10
- (b) We must all share our skills and knowledge
- (c) Productivity must be improved if the nation is to be prosperous.

In the foregoing examples, there is the implication for a greater or lesser extent, that the speaker is advocating, a certain form of behaviour. Thus, 'must' unlike 'have to' typically, suggests that the speaker is exercising his/her authority.

Need, Have (got to)

'Need' is used, especially, in British English in certain contexts as the negative and question form of 'must' for example:

- (a) Need they make all that noise?
You needn't worry about the test
However, it is possible and indeed, more common even in British English, to replace the auxiliary 'need' by 'need to' or 'have to' accompanied by 'do-support' as in the following:

- (a) Do they need or have to make all that noise?
- (b) You don't need or have to worry about that test.
'Have got to' can also be substituted for 'must' with little or no difference of meanings. Like 'must', 'have got to' conveys a sense of logical necessity:

- (a) There 'has got to' be some mistakes (American English)
There must be some mistakes (British English)
- (b) To be healthy, a plant has to receive a good supply of both moisture and sunshine.

It can also convey a sense of obligation and compulsion:

- (a) You have got to be back at 10
- (b) We have all got to share our skills and knowledge.

Dare/Used to

These are marginal modals. 'Dare' is rarer in American English than in British English:

- (a) Dare he not to escape (British English)
- Doesn't he dare to escape (American English)

'Used to' denotes a habit or a state that existed in the past. It always takes the “- to infinitive” and only occurs in the past tense.

- (a) She used to attend class regularly.
- (b) Ngozi used to be interested in swimming

'Used to' can occur as the first element in a verb phrase structure as demonstrated below:

- (b) He used not to smoke (British English)
- 'Used to' can occur with 'do – support' as exemplified:
He didn't use to smoke

The construction 'did use to' or 'didn't use to' is preferred to other constructions in both American and British Englishes.

However, apart from the central and marginal modals, there are other classes of modals which are very close to the marginal modals. Such categories are modal idioms, semi-auxiliaries and catenative verbs. Modal idioms contain the following multi-word verbs: “had better”, 'would rather', “have got to”, “be to”. They all begin with an auxiliary verb and followed by an infinitive sometimes preceded by “- to”. Examples abound:

- (a) We had better leave soon
- (b) I'd rather not to say anything
- (c) They have got to leave immediately

Besides, they cannot follow other verbs in the verb phrase structure. In most cases, they precede other verbs. The following examples are ungrammatical:

- * I would have got to leave soon
- * The conference has been to take place in Lagos.

Semi auxiliaries are verbal idioms which express modal or aspectual meaning introduced by such primary auxiliaries such as 'be and have'. They have fixed collocation. Some examples include 'be able to', 'be about to', 'be apt to', 'be bound to', 'be likely to', 'be meant to', 'be

obliged to', 'be supposed to', 'be willing', 'have to', among others. Semi auxiliaries introduced by the primary verb: “be” satisfy the seven criteria for auxiliary verbs. 'Be going to' has the 'be' as the first element.

- (a) Ada isn't going to swim
- (b) Is Ada going to swim?

In practice, the catenative verb constructions denote verbs in such construction as 'appear to', 'come to', 'fail to', 'get to', 'happen to', 'manage to', 'seem to', 'tend to', 'turn to'. Catenatives are closer to modal verb constructions because they can take the 'do-support' in the same environment. E.g., Chinagorom didn't (appear/come) to realise the importance of the project.

Modal	Have	Be	Be	Lexical Verb
Might		been	being	washed
Must	have	be		looking
would	have	been		writing
	has		to be	hidden
		was	being	examined
	has		to be	elected

(Source: Ndimele, *Advanced...* 110)

Pronouns

As a member of the closed-class system, a pronoun is a word used in substitution for a noun. This is normally, done to avoid redundant expressions and monotonous constructions. In his opinion, Onyema Ahaotu states: “although English pronouns are very few compared to nouns that they represent, the pronoun class fulfills a crucial role of infusing beauty and elegance in speech and writing” (57).

Kinds of Pronouns

There are five kinds of pronouns in English and they include: personal, relative, demonstrative, interrogative and indefinite pronouns.

Personal Pronouns

This subclass of pronouns refers to a person, or thing. This form indicates

whether it refers to the speaker (first person), addressee – person spoken to (second person) or the person(s)/thing(s) spoken of third person). The table below describes the various forms of personal pronouns. Language learners need to understand the various changes which these pronouns undergo when they are used in different contexts as different sentence elements. It is noteworthy that while nouns do not change their spellings, forms whether serving as subjects or object of sentences, pronouns have different words that are used in each case that requires a different element of the sentence. Some examples suffice here:

- 1a. Emeka gave the children a packet of biscuits
- b. He gave them a packet of biscuits
- 2a. The children thanked Emeka and were excited
- b. They thank him and were excited

The Person in Personal Pronouns

Pronoun	Referents
I	1 st person singular
We	1 st personal plural
You	2 nd person singular
You	2 nd person plural
He	3 rd person, male singular
She	3 rd person, female singular
It	3 rd person, neuter singular
They	3 rd person plural

Case Forms of Personal Pronouns

These refer to the various form of a personal pronoun that may be appropriately used in different element slots in a sentence. The table below suffices:

Subjective	Objective	Possessive	Determiner	Reflexive
I	me	mine	my	myself
We	us	ours	our	ourselves
You (sg)	you	yours	your	yourself
You (pl)	you	yours	your	yourselves
He	him	his	his	himself
She	her	hers	her	herself
It	it	its	-nil-	itself
They	them	theirs	their	themselves

From the foregoing, the subjective case is the form a personal pronoun takes when it occupies a subject slot of any English sentence while the same thing applies to the objective case as the form such pronouns take as either a direct object or an indirect objects in any sentence in English. The subject and object are all elements of English sentences. The possessive case is a mark of ownership or possession. The determiners usually, occur before nouns while the reflexives are used to point back to a person or pronoun that occurs before it in the same sentence. They are also described as compound personal pronouns.

Relative Pronouns

These pronouns are 'which', 'that', 'what' and 'who'. 'Who' is a subject case and has two other forms: the objective, 'whom' and the determiner, 'whose'. These forms may be combined with “-ever” or “-soever” to produce compound relative pronouns such as:

Whichever	whatever
Whoever	whosoever
Whomever	whomsoever
Whosoever	whatsoever

Relative pronouns normally introduce a subordinate clause in a complex sentence:

- (a) Here is Doctor Tunde whom I told you about
- (b) We saw the horse that (or which) won the race (Ahaotu 66). They are also referents to antecedent (noun), Doctor Tunde.

Demonstrative Pronouns

These pronouns point out particular persons, places or things. There are two demonstratives in English and they include: 'This' (singular), 'these' (plural), 'that' (singular), 'those' (plural).

However, 'this' and 'these' are known as proximate demonstratives because they point to objects that are closer or nearer to the speaker while 'that' and 'those' are referred to distal demonstratives because they point to objects that are faraway from the speaker. Some examples include:

This is my house
That table belongs to you
These are my friends
Those are your books

Interrogative Pronouns

These are pronouns which are used in asking questions. They include: 'what', 'which', and 'who' ('whom' and 'whose'):

Who is there?
What is your name?
Which road did he take?
Whose car did you go out with?
From whom did you borrow the money from?

Indefinite Pronouns

Excluding other subclasses of pronouns discussed in this section, a large group of them are called indefinite pronouns and they are: 'both', 'few', 'all', 'everyone', 'each one', 'much', 'several', 'no one', 'each other', 'everybody', 'anyone', 'everything', 'someone', 'none', 'neither', 'nothing', 'one', 'one another', 'any', 'some', 'either', 'each' 'no body', 'something', etc.

Indefinite pronouns are always used in the singular because they refer to non-definite nouns. Many of their possessive cases are formed by adding the apostrophe and 's to the indefinite pronoun; everybody's, someone's, anyone's and many more others. As representatives of nouns, pronouns function in the same manner as nouns which they substitute in grammatical structures.

CONCLUSION

This paper focuses principally, on the closed – class system of word classes in the English grammar. Having considered their major features or characteristics, the work also hinges on the criteria for word class identification and evinces that function remains more dependable and reliable in this regard. Evidently, as provided for in this text, function (primary criterion) takes preeminence over form and meaning which traditional grammar based its judgment. For classifying words into 'eight parts of speech'; we paid particular attention to the roles or functions of these words when used in larger grammatical constructions or structures such as phrases, clauses and sentences.

The whole essence is to improve on the works or teachings of grammar as this foundation was laid by traditional grammarians. This is not a decoy to disparage them but an applause because we have built on the foundations started by them. In English grammar, word class membership or association should be determined by the role, function such words play in sentences and not merely by their morphological shape (form) or semantic relations or implications (meaning). As practically demonstrated, here, the duo have proved insufficient and inefficient to decide or determine word class. It is function which has proved reliable and never fails. Knowledge of word class is key in proper comprehension of the workings of English Grammar and as such, second language users must have a good mastery of them and their different behavioural patterns. The knowledge of sounds, words, meanings and their roles in larger constructions are very important in knowing a language, in this

case, English and its grammar.

CONTRIBUTION TO KNOWLEDGE

The paper contributes by consolidating knowledge of closed-class systems (auxiliaries and pronouns) and emphasizing “function” (syntax) as a reliable criterion.

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